

Motorola Xoom?

Motorola's iPad killer might be called the Xoom; it's said to be based on the Android 3.0 platform

Palm Pad

Palm too is said to be showing off their WebOS powered tablet called the PalmPad

Tablet test

well stay away as the Galaxy Tab refuses to suck any sort of power fed through USB port, charging about 10 per cent in the three hours we plugged it in.

On a whole the tablet is impressive but could repel potential buyers with its hefty price tag. And could the smudge-loving screen haunt it? Not until we have an alternative.

DELL STREAK

The Dell Streak is a hybrid and, with its 5-inch screen, falls in the space between the current smartphones and tablets. If you don't think that the Streak is too large to be a phone, or too small to be a tablet, here is the rest of the story

When we unboxed the Streak, we fell for the device without even having powered it on: The piano black front, makes the screen look monolithic. The curves of the edges, are not just pleasing to the eye, but also make holding this device easier.

This hybrid (or tablet, in context to this test) indeed has very good handling owing to its slim profile and a beautiful matte finish on the back. The build of the device is very nearly perfect – metallic, yet light at 220 grams. Perhaps the only fault is a not-so-well-fitting back cover. Also, removing it switches the tablet off.

The colours on Streak are perhaps not as bright as on the excellent Galaxy Tab, but the detail is excellent, with great viewing angles.

For a capacitive screen, Dell Streak has a poor touch. Also, the screen recognises only two touches, as opposed to five that the Galaxy Tab recognised.

Dell Streak was criticised at launch because it forced the user to operate the device in only landscape mode. But thankfully, Android 2.2 upgrade allows the device to operate in both landscape and portrait mode.

The OS on the Streak comes with Dell's Stage UI, which follows the 'cards' concept like the new Palm 2.0 OS and the Blackberry 6 OS with the introduction of 'Stage widgets'. Each 'Stage' will hold information about one specific function of the device. Eg. Music, social and contacts. Running a finger along the bottom of the screen leads to a quick scroll between the various Stage widgets. Very handy.

The OS doesn't seem fully cooked on the device yet. Dell have added superficial customisation, they haven't added something really useful, like the Task Manager on Galaxy Tab.

E-mail, Gallery and Android Market provide the usual experience on Streak. The device relies solely on the Gallery app to play videos, which is probably the reason for very poor native video playback support. It played up MP4 files (up to 720p). The stock Android music player does a decent job. The bundled earphones are very light and comfortable, and come with three different sizes of ear plugs. The sound is balanced, though it is not very lively or loud.



You have to rely on Google's bundled internet-powered 'Navigation' app. 'Zinio Reader' provides magazines and QuickOffice can be used for basic editing of documents on the go.

The battery life of the device is decent, more because it has to power a smaller screen as compared to the other tablets. However, be careful if the earthing at your place is poor, because as we charged this phone through our laptop the touchscreen went berserk. Highly undesired.

So, is the beauty of the Dell Streak skin deep? Not with the latest Android. The biggest let down is the touchscreen of the device.

However, the Streak might attract many buyers simply because of its looks and form factor. After all, it is the only tablet in our test that might actually fit in your pocket. But then again, is it a tablet? Wouldn't a tablet buyer go for the 'intended' larger screen? We leave it to you to answer these questions.

ANDROID

Google, in collaboration with the other companies of the Open Handset Alliance, open-sourced and took forward the Android operating system, initially developed by Android Inc. The OS has grown in leaps and bounds since the earlier versions, and is still undergoing constant refinement on its way to becoming the king of mobile operating systems. The various major versions of Android have been 1.5 (Cupcake), 1.6 (Donut), 2.1 (Eclair) and 2.2 (Frozen yoghurt or FroYo). Android has its own application store called Android Market, which is one of the major reasons for the rising popularity of this mobile OS. Being open-source, the OS has our thumbs up, and has also led to the formation of a dedicated community of developers bringing out custom versions of the OS, which makes sure that you don't have to rely only on the manufacturer to modify the operating system to your likes (for more, refer to 'Rooting for nOObs', in December 2010 issue). Android 2.2 is the latest version of Android, with version 2.3 (Gingerbread) having just been released as I pen this down. Expect great things from this operating system in the times to come.

APPLE IPAD

If you have ever had a serious thought about buying a tablet, you probably already know all about the iPad. But has the tablet that started this mad-rush still got it enough to fend off smaller, faster challengers? We laid our hands on the iPad after we had thoroughly gone through the Galaxy Tab, Dell streak etc. We couldn't help but compare, compare, compare.

They don't build them as fine as the unibody construction of the iPad. All aluminium back and a 10-inch screen covering the entire front. The iPad is solidly built; too solidly maybe. The aluminium that provides this device a majestic touch also makes it heavy.

With newer hardware and more RAM, and the new pace injected in Android 2.2, Galaxy Tab clearly outperforms the iPad. By no means is iOS sluggish, but team Android has cut down loading times to negligible.